

Legend of the Blue Valley

Prem and his friend Shaam had gone to the Blue Valley for a holiday and had **checked into** the only hotel there.

"Not many guests, huh?" Prem asked the **bellhop** as he took them to their room.

"Business will pick up very soon when people hear about the legend," he replied with a smile.

"What legend?" asked Prem.

"There's this girl named Salona who is believed to **haunt** this place. Tourists will come here hoping to get a **glimpse** of her."

"By this place you mean the **valley**, don't you?" Prem asked weakly and was relieved when the man **nodded** his head.

"It's dark so let's not go out into the valley," Shaam said to Prem.

After dinner, they turned on the TV. Unfortunately, all the channels showed horror movies. So, they switched off the TV and went to sleep with the lights on.

It was almost midnight. Shaam could not sleep. Close to his bed was a window. Suddenly he saw a flash of white **going past**. **Scared out of his wits**, he tried to **wake up** Prem.

Prem got up with a start. "What's the matter?" he asked.

"I saw the lady!" cried Shaam.

"Where?" asked Prem, looking fearfully around the room. Shaam pointed towards the window. Prem couldn't see anything there.

"You must have had a **nightmare**!" said Prem. "Go back to sleep."

Just then, they heard sounds outside their room. **Cautiously**, the boys went to the door and opened it slightly. They saw a lady dressed in white clothes knocking at the door of the room opposite theirs.

Terror **stricken**, they **shut** the door and locked it.

"Did you check if she had **inverted** feet?" asked Prem when suddenly there was a knock on their door.

The boys ran and hid under the bed. Shaam **stuffed** his **kerchief** in his mouth to prevent himself from **screaming**. They waited **with bated breath** hoping that the person would go away.

A little later, the knocking **ceased**. The boys got out from under the bed and decided to leave the hotel immediately. But neither of them had the **courage** to open the door.



"Let's jump out of the window," suggested Shaam. Prem agreed. He looked out of the window and saw a thick, strong pipe leading to the ground. He climbed out of the window and slid down the pipe. Shaam **followed suit**. Just as they were running towards the gate, they **collided** with the hotel manager.

"Where are you boys going at this time of the night?" he asked. They told him how they had seen Salona. The manager laughed.

"Don't be frightened! Our hotel people have created this story to attract tourists. Looks like it has been successful," said the manager. He told them that the woman they had seen was Naina, who was on their **payroll**. She has been told to make an appearance at night to make people believe that the legend was true.

Just then, they saw Naina, the lady in white, walking slowly in their direction.



Emboldened by what they had heard, the boys **waved out** to her **cheerfully** when an employee came running to the manager, saying, "Sir, Naina called just now saying that she is **down with the flu** and will not be able to come tonight and tomorrow."

"But...then... who is that?" asked the manager pointing towards the figure in white, who was coming towards them.

"Ghost!?" cried the boys, **horrified**. They ran as fast as their legs could carry them all the way to the station and only when they were seated inside the train that was leaving for their hometown, did they **heave a sigh of relief**.

"I **wonder** what happened back at the hotel!" said Prem.

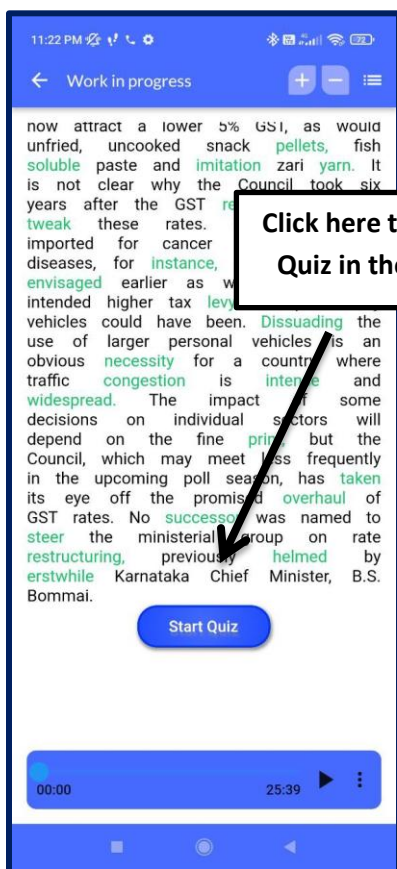
"I know only one thing," said Shaam, "and that is, I don't want to ever return to the Blue Valley again!"

Vocabulary

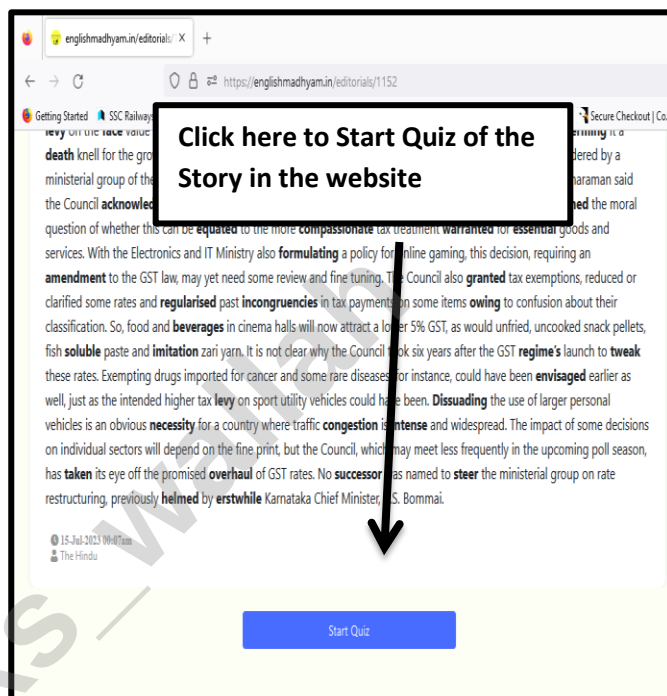
1. **Check** (into) (verb) – register, book, sign in, enroll, lodge in होटल में प्रवेश करना
2. **Bellhop** (noun) – porter, attendant, hotel boy, luggage carrier, doorman होटल सहायक
3. **Haunt** (verb) – appear, visit, ghost, obsess, linger भूत-प्रेत का दिखना / डराना
4. **Glimpse** (noun) – sight, peek, glance, view, flash झलक
5. **Valley** (noun) – dale, basin, gorge, ravine, lowland घाटी
6. **Nod** (verb) – signal, gesture, incline, bow, agree सिर हिलाकर संकेत देना
7. **Go past** (phrase) – pass by, move beyond, walk past, cross, overtake पार जाना
8. **Scare out of one's wits** (phrase) – terrify, startle, frighten badly, alarm, horrify बुरी तरह से डरा देना
9. **Wake up** (phrasal verb) – awaken, get up, rouse, stir, arise उठ जाना / जगना
10. **Nightmare** (noun) – bad dream, horror, terror, dread, vision डरावना सपना
11. **Cautiously** (adverb) – carefully, warily, prudently, alertly, attentively सतर्कतापूर्वक
12. **Stricken** (adjective) – shocked, overwhelmed, afflicted, seized, troubled पीड़ित / व्यथित
13. **Shut** (verb) – close, seal, lock, slam, block बंद करना
14. **Inverted** (adjective) – turned upside down, reversed, flipped, backward, opposite उल्टा
15. **Stuff** (verb) – push, cram, fill, jam, pack ठूसना / भर देना
16. **Kerchief** (noun) – handkerchief, cloth, scarf, napkin, tissue रुमाल
17. **Screaming** (noun) – shouting, yelling, shrieking, crying, hollering चीखना
18. **With bated breath** (phrase) – anxiously, nervously, tensely, breathlessly, with suspense सांस रोककर / उत्सुकता से
19. **Cease** (verb) – stop, end, halt, discontinue, terminate रुक जाना
20. **Courage** (noun) – bravery, valor, boldness, fearlessness, determination साहस
21. **Follow suit** (phrase) – do the same, imitate, replicate, copy, repeat पीछे से वही करना
22. **Collide** (verb) – crash, bump, strike, clash, smash टकरा जाना

23. **Payroll** (noun) – staff list, wage list, employment record, pay register, employee count वेतन सूची / कर्मचारी सूची
24. **Embolden** (verb) – encourage, inspire, strengthen, motivate, boost हिम्मत देना
25. **Wave out** (phrasal verb) – greet, gesture goodbye, signal, beckon हाथ हिलाकर अभिवादन करना
26. **Cheerfully** (adverb) – happily, joyfully, brightly, merrily, optimistically खुशी से
27. **Down with the flu** (phrase) – ill, unwell, sick, suffering, bedridden फ्लू से पीड़ित
28. **Horrify** (verb) – terrify, shock, frighten, appall, alarm भयभीत कर देना
29. **Heave a sigh of relief** (phrase) – relax, feel reassured, calm down, be relieved राहत की सांस लेना
30. **Wonder** (verb) – ponder, think, question, speculate, marvel आश्चर्य करना / सोचना

Practice Exercise



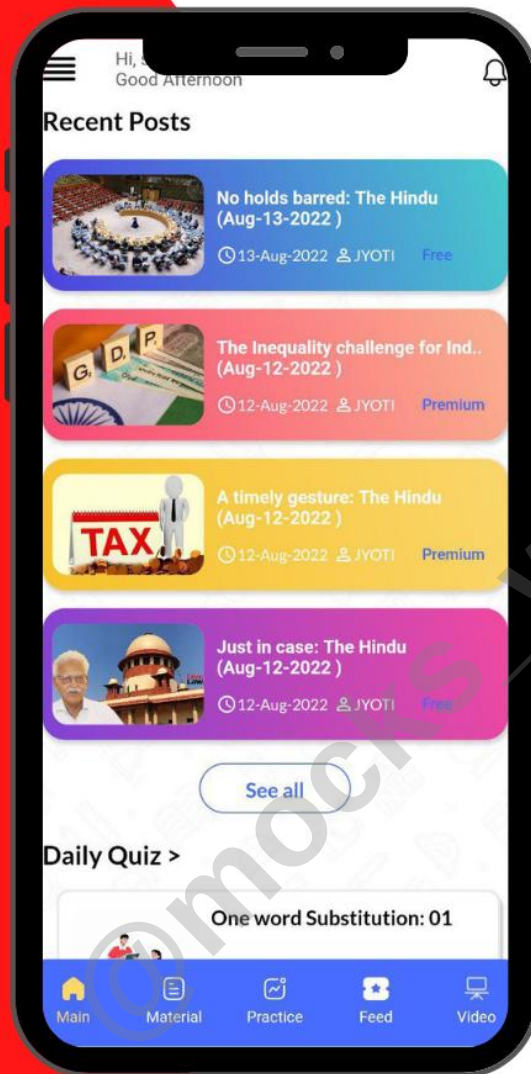
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